

Germany wants to get tougher on Chinese EVs

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【要点】

- ・ドイツのメルツ首相は、中国製ハイブリッド車の輸入増加を抑制するための強硬な貿易措置を求めており、10月にEUに正式提案を提出する予定である。
- ・ドイツの自動車メーカーは当初、中国からの報復を恐れて中国EV関税に反対していたが、中国市場での競争力低下とヨーロッパでの中国製ハイブリッド車の増加により、立場を変えて貿易措置の導入を支持するようになった。
- ・フォルクスワーゲンを含むドイツの自動車メーカーは、プラグインハイブリッド車が関税で保護されていない状況を改善し、公正な競争環境を構築するようEUに求めている。
- ・中国自動車メーカーは2024年第2四半期に西ヨーロッパの市場シェアの約11%を占め、初めて日本ブランドと同等の市場シェアを達成した。

【メール原文】

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By TOMMASO LECCA

with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO

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SNEAK PEEK

— Berlin will put forward its proposal this fall for taking tougher trade action against China to curb the import of hybrid vehicles.

— Russia's blockade of Ukraine's Black Sea ports is turning a maritime crisis into a European transport problem, forcing more Ukrainian freight onto EU ports, railways and roads that are already under pressure.

— The EU Aviation Safety Agency ordered wing fixes on more than 100 Airbus A350 aircraft after the manufacturer identified an issue that could compromise protection against lightning strikes.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

MERZ BACKS TRADE ACTION ON CHINA: Berlin wants the European Commission to take action to curb the surge of imports of Chinese hybrid vehicles, Chancellor Friedrich Merz indicated at a press conference on Wednesday following a Cabinet retreat. When asked if he supported some industry demands for tougher trade measures on hybrid vehicles, Merz said Berlin would put forward its official proposal to the EU in October.

In his words: “We note that German industry, too, has evidently changed its position regarding these global imbalances. And we will not only address this issue but also make decisions,” Merz said. “Trade policy is the responsibility of the European Union. But the European Union is waiting for a clear German position, and that will be presented in October.”

A reversal: Initially, German automakers, fearing retribution from Beijing, were against imposing duties on Chinese electric vehicles. Consequently, Berlin had lobbied hard against the Commission’s anti-subsidy investigation and subsequent duties on made-in-China EVs. But the brands are losing ground fast in China, and the increase in Chinese hybrids in Europe puts their home market at risk.

Industry alignment: German carmaker Volkswagen is now also advocating that the Commission institute trade measures to create a “level playing field” on hybrids, CEO Oliver Blume told investors in a July earnings call . Plug-in hybrids are “not protected with tariffs right now” and “that is a task for the European Union to establish quickly,” he said.

Chinese gaining ground: Chinese automakers took nearly 11 percent of the market share in Western Europe in the second quarter of this year, according to data from Schmidt Automotive Research . They now have the same market share as Japanese brands for the first time, the consultancy said in a report released Wednesday that was seen by POLITICO.

It gets worse: When looking only at plug-in hybrids, Chinese automakers took 28 percent of the market share in Western Europe during the second quarter, the Schmidt data showed.

Grass is greener: Chinese automakers — and their European peers — are struggling in China, which is dealing with a sluggish economy and overcapacity. Vehicle sales in China dropped 21 percent year-over-year in July. Chinese car companies are turning to exports, and Europe is the largest available market, with the U.S. essentially closed off to them.

Imports increasing: The value of vehicle and automotive part imports from China to the EU grew from €14.5 billion in the first half of 2025 to over €20 billion over the same period this year, according to Eurostat data released on Wednesday.

Political battle: While the Commission ultimately got enough yes votes from member countries to push through the EV duties, it cannot reopen the EV investigation to now impose duties on hybrid vehicles as well, but would instead need to launch a separate investigation into plug-in hybrids, a Commission source confirmed to POLITICO.

LOGISTICS

EUROPE FACES BLACK SEA BOTTLENECK: Russia’s effective blockade of Ukraine’s Black Sea ports is turning a maritime crisis into a European transport problem, forcing more Ukrainian freight onto the Danube River and through EU ports, railways and roads that are already under pressure.

A lot to reroute: Odesa and its two neighboring ports normally handle around 60 percent of Ukraine’s monthly exports, worth roughly \$3.5 billion, according to an Atlantic Council report . But repeated

Russian attacks on ports and merchant vessels have reduced shipping traffic to a fraction of normal levels, forcing more cargo to find another way out.

Enter the Danube: One alternative runs through Ukraine's smaller Danube ports, including Izmail and Reni, and onward to Romania's Constanța. But those ports are also facing frequent Russian drone attacks — and Europe's drought has pushed Danube water levels to record lows.

Less water, less cargo: Barges and other vessels can't carry their normal loads when the river runs low, limiting Ukrainian grain and oilseed exports as well as imports such as fuel. That, in turn, puts more pressure on road and rail links through neighboring countries.

Onto the rails: Ukraine, Moldova and private operators are trying to increase rail capacity, but that risks simply moving the bottleneck westward. Cargo still faces lengthy waits at Constanța, where Ukrainian transit traffic has to compete for capacity with Romanian freight.

Another obstacle: Cristian Vlas, think tank ACLED's assistant research manager for Eastern Europe, told Martina the group has recorded at least three strikes on border checkpoints around the Danube region. Most subsequently reopened, but further attacks could create another choke point on routes through Moldova.

Europe's headache: Moving more Ukrainian grain overland could also revive tensions with farmers in neighboring EU countries. Vlas said Romanian farmers have previously worried that Ukrainian produce meant only to transit the country could instead remain on the domestic market, while transport operators are already juggling competing demands for capacity.

No quick fix: Vlas expects the drone campaign to continue as long as both sides have the resources to sustain it. That leaves Europe with a growing transport challenge: keeping Ukrainian trade moving through its ports, rivers, railways and roads while those alternative routes come under increasing strain.

AVIATION

EASA ORDERS WING FIXES ON OVER 100 AIRBUS A350S: More than 100 Airbus A350s will have to undergo a technical fix under an airworthiness directive from the EU Aviation Safety Agency that takes effect Monday. The A350 is a wide-body aircraft primarily used on long-haul routes.

Airbus told Morning Mobility that the directive was issued after the manufacturer identified reduced clearance between two internal wing components, whose contact could damage a protective layer. The issue does not pose an immediate safety risk, but affected aircraft must be modified by the end of November, Airbus said.

What EASA said: The regulator intervened after "low clearance" was identified inside the wings of certain A350-1000s, potentially causing "intermittent physical contact" between components and damaging part of the aircraft's protection against lightning strikes. The directive applies to 108 A350s operated by more than 10 airlines, including Qatar Airways, British Airways, Cathay Pacific, Etihad Airways and Virgin Atlantic.

What might happen? If left uncorrected, the problem, "combined with an empty fuel tank, could create an ignition source for the fuel vapour inside the tanks," EASA said. Under those conditions, "in case of a lightning strike of high intensity in the immediate area, could possibly result in ignition of the fuel-air mixture in the affected fuel tank and consequent loss of the aeroplane," the directive adds. EASA noted that Airbus identified the problem and issued instructions to address it.

Not an immediate risk: "Airbus has identified the clearance between two internal wing components ... on some A350-1000 wings was reduced," said Henry Ashton, Airbus' U.K. chief engineer for the A350. "Contact between these two parts has the potential to erode primer/paint layers during specific loading, which can affect part of the Electromagnetic Hazard (EMH) protection for events like lightning strikes." When asked about the impact of EASA's directive on airline operations, he said: "By design, the EMH protection is multilayered, which means the affected aircraft under this airworthiness directive continue to be safe to fly."

The fix: The directive "requires airlines to apply sealant around the wing rib to cover attachment area to restore one of the EMH protections," Ashton said. "This action is required to be completed by the end of November 2026 and can be done during routine maintenance."

Airlines' reaction: Cathay Pacific, one of the carriers operating affected A350s, told Tommaso that "the required inspections will be incorporated into planned maintenance activities for the affected aircraft." The airline said it "do[es] not expect any impact on our operations." The other airlines contacted did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

FRANKFURT AIRPORT EMPLOYEE DIES AFTER CONTRACTING 'AIRPORT MALARIA': A Frankfurt Airport employee has died after contracting "a form of malaria known as airport malaria in connection with their work at the airport," the German hub announced Wednesday. Someone can contract so-called airport malaria when an infected tropical mosquito is transported on an international flight and bites someone near or in an airport.

The local public health authority informed the airport that a total of six employees had contracted the infection, Frankfurt Airport said in an emailed statement. The airport said it was informed of the employee's death by health authorities. The other five infected staff members are receiving medical treatment.

Trapping mosquitoes: According to German broadcaster Tagesschau, mosquitoes carrying malaria may have arrived in the cargo hold of an aircraft in July. "Mosquito traps have been installed at the airport," Frankfurt Airport said. "Mosquitoes captured in these traps will be genetically analyzed by the Institute of Tropical Medicine in Antwerp, Belgium, to determine their species and origin." A spokesperson for the Frankfurt Health Office said that "a human-to-human transmission plays no role in airport malaria."

PIT STOPS

According to weekly data from Eurocontrol, summer air traffic is 2.3 percent higher than the same period last year, but there are 19 percent fewer air traffic flow management delays.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Germany to set position on EU-China trade in October, Merz says

The German Government is currently drawing up measures for a tougher trade policy.

By Romanus Otte · Aug 26, 2026, 04:34 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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